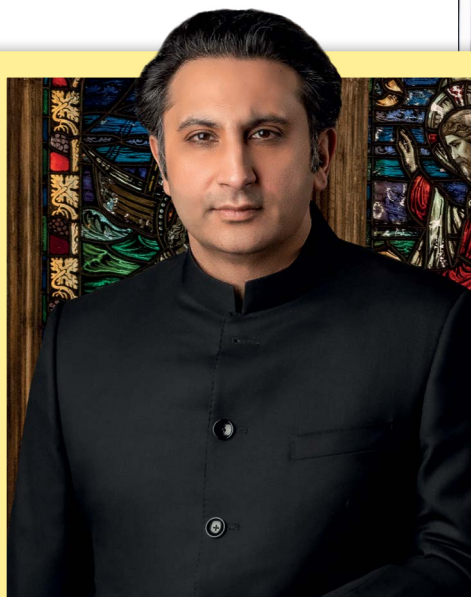




THE FILM SCRIPT

Adar Poonawalla-led Serene Productions bought a 50% stake in Dharma Production and Dharmatic Entertainment, headed by filmmaker Karan Johar, for ₹1,000 crore. Johar retains the other half of the companies and will be the Executive Chairman



PHOTOS BY BANDEEP SINGH

to ₹118 crore in FY21. They recovered in FY23 to ₹1,040 crore. But profit after tax in FY23 was just ₹11 crore, down from a PAT of ₹37 crore on revenues of ₹276 crore in FY22. But the recovery in sales did not last. In FY24, sales dipped by more than half to ₹512 crore, and Dharma was barely profitable, reporting a PAT of just ₹60 lakh.

Discussions with Saregama and Reliance Industries went nowhere, with the valuation proving to be the sticking point. So, when Poonawalla-led Serene Productions an-

nounced that it was paying ₹1,000 crore for a 50% stake in Dharma, it came as a surprise. Johar retains the other half of the companies and will be the Executive Chairman, overseeing operations.

Poonawalla tells *BT* that Dharma's strong brand recognition was one reason he made the deal. "Over the next few years, we see Dharma building India's strongest and entertainment first, global-facing content portfolio," he says.

Poonawalla says the traditional theatrical model is evolving, and

the new approach will balance big films with digital-only content. "[Return on investment] is measured not just by the box office, but by the strength of the IP, longevity on streaming platforms, and licensing revenues across music, international sales, and merchandise," says Poonawalla.

Serum has spread its bets as it looks to recapture the heights of FY22. Will they inject a much-needed boost? **BT**

@neetu_csharma